

Pumping air

It is easy to squash together, or compress, gas molecules. When you pump up a tire, you compress air molecules into a small space. The more air molecules you pump in, the more they push against the inside of the tire. The tire gets harder because pressure increases inside it.



High pressure

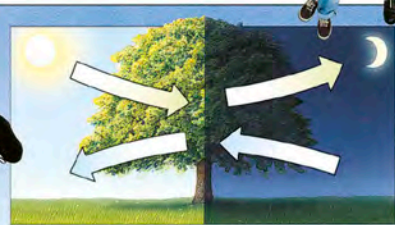
Air presses on everything on Earth. You can see air pressure at work. If you suck juice out of a carton, the carton buckles. This is because the air pressure pushing on the carton is greater than the air pressure inside the carton.

Molecules in a gas move very quickly, darting around in all directions.



Out of breath

Gases can dissolve in liquids, and oxygen from the air dissolves in water. Fish need oxygen to breathe, so they use the oxygen in water to survive under water. Humans also breathe oxygen, but unlike fish, we can't breathe under water without a supply of compressed air.



Night and day

Plants help keep the balance of gases in the air. Night and day, they take in oxygen and "breathe out" carbon dioxide, as we do. But by day, they also take in large amounts of carbon dioxide—which they need to make their food and give off oxygen.